Hawassa University

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Faculty of Informatics

Department of Computer Science

Research Proposal

Enhancing Web Application Security Using AI-Based Threat Detection Systems

Course: Research Methods in Computer Science (CoSc3101)

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GitHub: https://github.com/Abayshemelis/ResearchProposalPaper

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1 Introduction

The global digital ecosystem now depends on web applications for critical operations in commerce, healthcare, and education, making their security a non-negotiable prerequisite for organizational stability and user trust. However, as services rapidly digitize, traditional defensive perimeters based on static signatures have become fundamentally inadequate against the industrialization of attacker automation. Empirical studies show that mutated and obfuscated payloads can bypass commonly deployed rule-based platforms with evasion rates reaching as high as 79%, contributing to a global average data breach cost of 4.44 million in 2025. This research proposes a shift from reactive, deterministic filters to adaptive, AI-enhanced architectures that learn "normality" through behavioral analytics. By leveraging machine learning models that achieve detection rates between 94% and 99% while maintaining microsecond-level latency ($< 200\mu s$), this study aims to deliver a proactive security framework capable of neutralizing zero-day threats at the high speeds required for modern edge-native environments.

2 Problem Statement

Despite advancements, the cybersecurity community faces a "complexity crisis". In 2025 alone, 48,185 Common Vulnerabilities and Exposures (CVEs) were published, representing a 20.6% increase from the previous year. On average, 133 new vulnerabilities surface daily, with Cross-Site Scripting (XSS) and SQL Injection (SQLi) remaining the most prevalent.

Current signature-based Web Application Firewalls (WAFs) fail to detect novel zero-day attacks, which hit 90 confirmed cases in 2025. Furthermore, modern AI-based solutions often operate as "black boxes," leading to alert fatigue among analysts due to a lack of explainability. The consequences are devastating: the average cost of a data breach escalated to $4.88 million in 2024, causing significant financial loss and long-term reputational damage.

3 Objectives

3.1 General Objective

To develop a robust, explainable AI-enhanced detection framework that proactively identifies known and zero-day web vulnerabilities with high accuracy and minimal latency.

3.2 Specific Objectives

- To design a hybrid model combining CNN and LSTM architectures to achieve an F1-score $\geq 95\%$ on the SR-BH 2020 dataset by week 5.
- To integrate SHAP-based Explainable AI (XAI) to provide real-time interpretability, aiming to reduce analyst response time by 30%.
- To optimize inference architecture to ensure 90% of requests are processed within a 60-millisecond window.

4 Literature Review

Recent advances in web application security research indicate a clear paradigm shift toward the use of deep learning (DL) models for defending the semantic layer of modern systems. For instance, [1] demonstrated that Transformer-based architectures such as CodeBERT significantly outperform traditional signature-based and statistical methods by capturing the contextual semantics of structured queries, particularly in detecting sophisticated SQL injection patterns. In parallel, hybrid architectures combining Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) and Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks have shown strong performance in modeling both spatial and temporal characteristics of network traffic, enabling improved detection of evolving attack behaviors [2]. Furthermore, the integration of explainability has emerged as a requirement for trust, as explored by [3] in the context of intrusion detection.

Despite these advancements, a critical limitation persists in the current state-of-the-art: most systems fail to simultaneously achieve high detection accuracy, real-time process-

ing capability, and model interpretability. High-performing deep learning models often operate as opaque "black boxes," limiting their practical usability in security operations where explainability is essential for trust and rapid incident response. Additionally, the computational overhead of complex models introduces latency constraints, making them unsuitable for high-throughput, edge-native environments [4].

To address this gap, this research proposes a novel architecture that integrates a low-latency neural inference engine with an out-of-band Explainable AI (XAI) interpreter. This design decouples detection from explanation, enabling real-time threat identification while asynchronously generating human-readable justifications. As a result, the proposed framework aims to achieve a balanced trade-off between accuracy, interpretability, and performance, making it suitable for deployment in modern, high-traffic web application environments.

4.1 Synthesis Matrix

Table 1: Synthesis Matrix of Related Work

Author	**Method**	**Dataset**	**Metric**	**Limitation**
Ammar & Alharbi (2025)	CodeBERT Transformer	Kaggle SQLi	99.9% Acc.	High computational cost
Thalji et al. (2023)	Autoencoder	SQL Queries	99% Acc.	Limited recall
Sekyewa et al. (2023)	Transformer + Ensemble	Web Logs	High accuracy	No latency study
IMSA (2024)	ML Ensemble	Web Data	99.3% Acc.	Adversarial risk
AlgoXSSF (2024)	ML Framework	Breach Logs	Real-time	No prevention layer

5 Technical Methodology & Experimental Design

5.1 System Architecture and Functional Flow

The overall system architecture of the proposed AI-enhanced web application security framework is illustrated in Fig. 1. The design follows a sequential processing pipeline

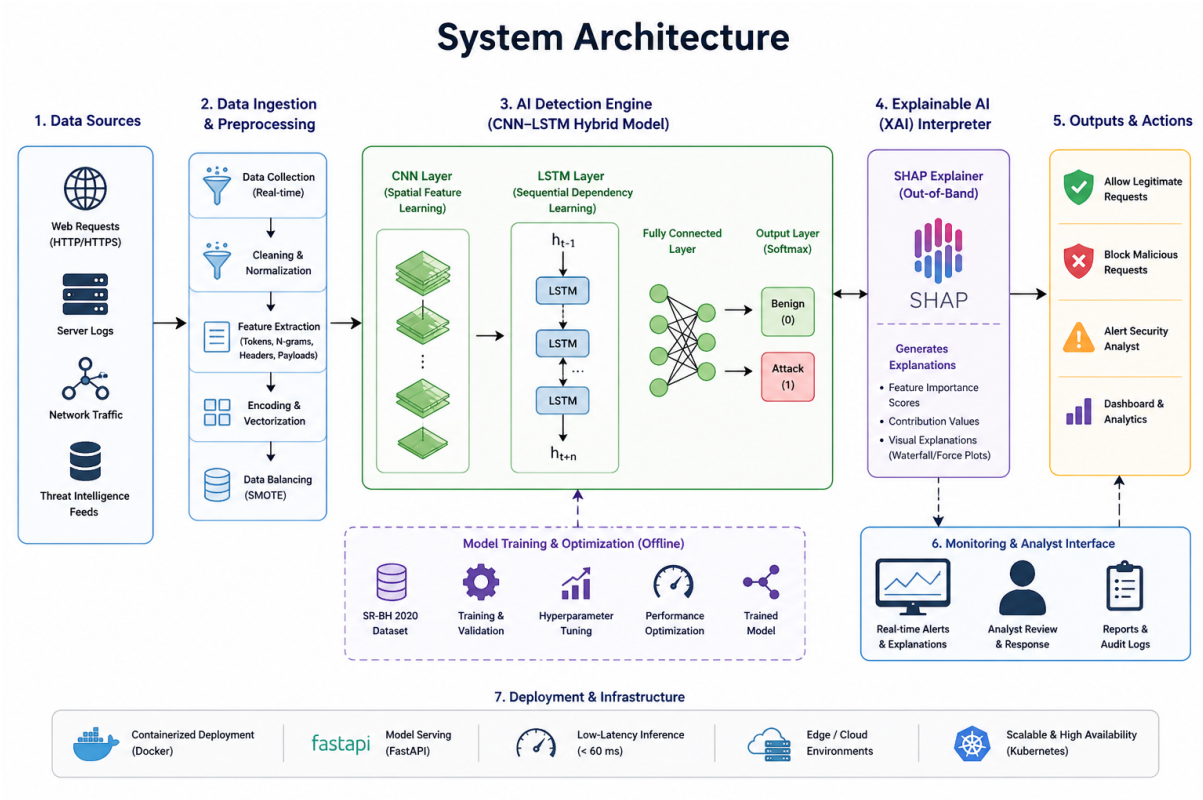

Figure 1: Proposed system architecture of the AI-enhanced web application security framework. The system integrates data ingestion, preprocessing, a hybrid CNN-LSTM detection engine, and an out-of-band SHAP-based explainable AI module for real-time threat detection and interpretation.

The framework consists of four primary modules:

that balances high-speed threat detection with deep interpretability.

1. **Ingestion Layer:** Captures raw HTTP traffic via TAP/SPAN ports, ensuring zero impact on the primary network path and preserving system performance.

2. **Pre-processing Module:** Performs URL decoding, syntactic normalization, and tokenization using Byte Pair Encoding (BPE), transforming raw input into structured numerical tensors suitable for machine learning.

3. **AI Detection Engine:** Utilizes a hybrid CNN-LSTM architecture, where the CNN extracts spatial features from request payloads and the LSTM models temporal dependencies across sequential attack patterns.

4. **XAI Interpreter:** Applies SHAP (SHapley Additive exPlanations) to compute feature attribution scores, enabling transparent and human-readable explanations for each detected threat.

Functional Flow: Data processing begins at the ingestion layer, where traffic is mirrored and forwarded to the preprocessing module for cleaning and normalization. The processed tensors are then passed to the AI detection engine, which classifies requests as benign or malicious. Upon detection of a threat, the XAI interpreter generates feature attribution scores, mapping the model's decision back to the original input to provide a clear and interpretable justification for the alert.

5.1.1 Operational Performance

To ensure suitability for real-time, high-traffic environments, detection latency (ΔT) is defined as:

$$\Delta T = (T_{\text{pre-process}} + T_{\text{inference}} + T_{\text{XAI}}) < 60 \text{ ms} \tag{1}$$

This constraint ensures that the system maintains both high detection accuracy and low-latency performance required for deployment in modern web infrastructures.

5.2 Tool Justification

PyTorch is the primary framework due to its dynamic graph support, which is superior for rapid prototyping of custom attention mechanisms compared to TensorFlow. **Burp Suite** will be used to generate adversarial payloads to test model robustness.

5.3 Data Strategy

This study utilizes the SR-BH 2020 multi-label dataset from IEEE DataPort, which provides a comprehensive collection of real-world web traffic categorized by CAPEC attack patterns [5]. This dataset is critical for addressing the modern "complexity crisis" in web security by providing high-fidelity logs for training.

To address the inherent class imbalance between benign traffic and specific malicious vectors—a common challenge in network intrusion detection—the Synthetic Minority Over-sampling Technique (SMOTE) is applied. This method generates synthetic samples for minority attack classes to prevent model bias and improve detection fairness [2].

Basic preprocessing steps, including syntactic normalization and Byte Pair Encoding (BPE), are performed to convert raw HTTP payloads into structured numerical tensors suitable for the CNN-LSTM detection engine. This multi-step strategy ensures improved data balance, higher model accuracy, and an enhanced capability to detect diverse, polymorphic attack types [4].

5.4 Evaluation Metrics

The performance of the AI-based threat detection engine will be quantitatively evaluated using a confusion matrix-based approach. The following mathematical foundations will be used to prove the success of the model:

$$\text{Accuracy} = \frac{TP + TN}{TP + TN + FP + FN} \tag{2}$$

$$F1\text{-Score} = 2 \times \frac{\text{Precision} \times \text{Recall}}{\text{Precision} + \text{Recall}} \tag{3}$$

In addition to classification accuracy, the system must meet industrial performance benchmarks for real-time traffic analysis. We target a maximum detection latency of:

$$\Delta T < 60 \text{ ms} \tag{4}$$

This ensures that the security overhead does not negatively impact user experience or service availability.

I target a Detection Latency $\Delta T < 60$ ms to meet industrial standards.

6 PROJECT MANAGEMENT & ETHICS

6.1 Implementation Timeline (Gantt Chart)

The research proposal follows a 1-month from march 24/2026 - may 1/2026. Over all it is one month and one weeks research proposal implementation cycle as visualized below:

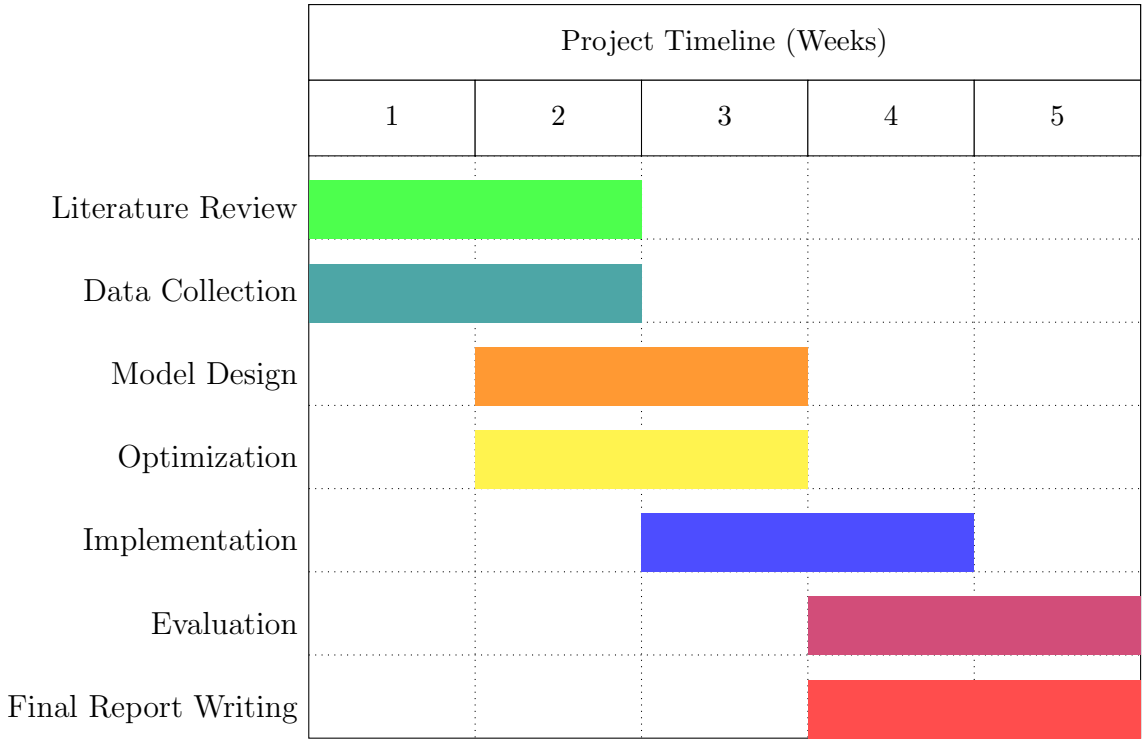

Figure 2: Weekly Implementation Timeline of the Research Proposal

6.2 Ethical Considerations

This research ensures data privacy by using anonymized datasets and complying with GDPR principles. Personally Identifiable Information (PII) is removed, and differential privacy techniques are applied to reduce data leakage risks.

To promote fairness, bias audits are conducted to prevent discrimination across different traffic patterns and user behaviors. Explainable AI methods (SHAP and LIME) are integrated to improve transparency and trust in model decisions.

The system is also designed to minimize false positives, ensuring that legitimate users are not incorrectly blocked. Regular testing is performed to reduce vulnerabilities to adversarial attacks.

Overall, the framework prioritizes privacy, fairness, transparency, and reliable security performance.

7 Version Control

.On my research i utilizes Git for state management and GitHub for remote collaboration and documentation [6]. The primary benefits include:

- **LaTeX Management:** Keeps modular report source files organized and prevents data loss during complex document compilations.
- **Scientific Reproducibility:** Tracks atomic changes in AI model architectures, hyperparameter tuning, and training dataset versions.
- **Future Scalability:** Enables seamless branching and merging for multi-contributor development and peer code review.
- **Auditability:** Replaces manual file versioning with a cryptographically secure, searchable history of all research iterations.

8 Standard Workflow

The following commands define the standardized interaction with the project repository to maintain synchronization between local and remote environments:

Listing 1: Git Basic Commands for Research Lifecycle

```
# Initialize the local research environment
git init

# Stage changes (LaTeX source, dataset samples, or Python scripts
    )
git add .

# Save a snapshot with a descriptive message for the audit trail
git commit -m "Integrated hybrid CNN-LSTM architecture and
    evaluation metrics"

# Upload local changes to the GitHub repository
git push origin main

# Sync local workspace with the latest remote updates
git pull origin main
```

References

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